Name: _____ Date: _____

Seafaring Societies of the Mediterranean

Key Terms
seafaring — traveling by sea for trade or exploration.
cultural exchange/diffusion — the sharing of ideas, art, and customs between groups.
city-state — a city that acts like its own independent country.

Between 2000 and 1400 B.C., a powerful group of people called the Minoans lived on the island of Crete. Crete is a large island in the Aegean Sea, and its location made it a perfect "stepping stone" for trade. Because they lived on an island, the Minoans became expert sailors. They traded beautiful pottery, sharp swords, and precious metal vessels with their neighbors. As they sailed from place to place, they did not just trade goods; they also shared their art, burial customs, and religious beliefs.



The remains of the Minoan capital at Knossos.

Archaeologists discovered the Minoan capital city, Knossos, in the late 19th century. They found a brilliant civilization that seemed very peaceful, as the cities did not have walls for protection. The culture was named after the legendary King Minos. According to stories, King Minos owned a Minotaur—a monster that was half-human and half-bull—which he kept hidden in a giant maze called a labyrinth.



A wall painting showing the sport of bull leaping.

Minoan art shows that they were athletic people who loved nature. They enjoyed sports like boxing, wrestling, and a dangerous activity called bull leaping, where gymnasts would somersault over the horns of a bull. Religion was also very important to them. They worshiped a great Mother Earth Goddess who ruled over their other gods. Women in Crete held a high rank, and priestesses often took charge of religious shrines.

The Minoan civilization came to a mysterious end around 1200 B.C. Scientists believe natural disasters played a role. In 1470 B.C., a series of earthquakes rocked the island, followed by a massive volcanic eruption on the nearby island of Thera. This created a giant tidal wave and buried the land in volcanic ash. While the Minoans tried to rebuild, they were weakened. Eventually, invaders from Greece likely took over the island, ending the Minoan age of sea power.

The Phoenician Traders

After the Minoans declined, the Phoenicians became the most powerful traders in the Mediterranean around 1100 B.C. They lived in the area we now call Lebanon. Unlike the Minoans, the Phoenicians were not one single country. Instead, they lived in wealthy city-states like Tyre, Sidon, and Byblos. Because they lived along a narrow coastal strip with mountains behind them, they looked to the sea for their survival.



Phoenician ships were designed to carry large amounts of trade goods.

The Phoenicians were remarkable shipbuilders. They invented the "round boat," which was wide and had a rounded bottom to create more space for cargo. They were the first Mediterranean people to sail out into the Atlantic Ocean. Some even believe they sailed all the way around the continent of Africa, a trip that took three years to complete. To help their trade, they built colonies along the coasts of Africa and Spain, including the famous city of Carthage.



The Phoenician alphabet used symbols to represent sounds.

The Phoenicians were famous for their crafts, especially a rare red-purple dye. This dye was made from a sea snail called the murex. It took 60,000 snails to make just one pound of dye, so only royalty could afford to wear purple cloth. They also traded cedar wood, glass, and ivory.

Perhaps their greatest legacy was the development of the alphabet. As merchants, they needed a quick way to record their business deals. They created a phonetic system where one sign stood for one sound. The word "alphabet" comes from their first two letters, *aleph* and *beth*. As they traded, they spread this writing system to other people, including the Greeks. This made learning to read and write much easier for everyone.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Whiteboard Activity: Cause and Effect

Directions: On the whiteboard, create a T-Chart or a Flowchart. Look through your reading to identify environmental factors (**Causes**) and the specific systems, beliefs, or technologies that were created as a result (**Effects**). Use the examples below to help you get started.

Example: Environment & Innovation

Cause (Environment)	Effect (System/Belief)
Island geography of Crete	Development of expert seafaring and trade
Coastal mountains in Phoenicia	Invention of 'round boats' for sea cargo

Environmental Impact Map



Part 2: Planning Your Board

Use the space below to draft at least three more cause-and-effect pairs from the text before you draw them on the whiteboard.

Environmental Cause	Resulting System, Belief, or Tech

Critical Thinking: Cultural Diffusion

The reading mentions that trade turned Crete into a 'stepping stone' and that Phoenicians spread their alphabet to trading partners like the Greeks. Based on your organizer, why is the sea a better tool for spreading ideas than traveling over land?